Among the Tibetans, the Qing emperors sought legitimacy by presenting themselves as the Buddhist Cakravartin or universal emperor. It is known that in 1635, a year before establishing the Qing dynasty at his capital Shenyang or Mukden, Hong Taiji had a Buddhist consecration ceremony held, at which he was granted the powers of Mahakala, the Buddhist deity protecting the faith. Qing rulers were often depicted as incarnations of Manjusri, the Bodhisattva of wisdom in the Mahayana Buddhist pantheon. Therefore, the claim of Sinicization ignores these other dimensions of Qing rulership. As pointed out by Evelyn S. Rawski,

> . . . the key to Qing success, at least in terms of empire building, lay in its ability to use its cultural links with the non-Han peoples of Inner Asia and to differentiate the administration of the former Ming provinces. [2]

The argument that the Qing had to Sinicize in order to rule is also unable to explain why, if they had indeed been accepted as having become a ‘native’ empire, there were frequent revolts against them by Han communities. As mentioned earlier, the leader of the Chinese republican revolution, Sun Yat-sen had no doubt that the revolution was targeted against an alien regime which had oppressed the Han people.

The identity of the Qing is important because contemporary China’s claim to territories conquered by the Qing hinges on whether these conquests were the expansion of the territory of China or distinct from the latter. Several Chinese scholars have argued that in their official documents, including diplomatic correspondence, the Qing referred to themselves as representing ‘Zhongguo’, the Middle Country or China. The text of the Nerchinsk Treaty between China and Russia, signed in 1689, has been cited as evidence, where the term Zhongguo is used to represent the Qing empire. While this may be the case, it does not imply that the Qing rulers regarded their conquests in Inner Asia to be seen merely as extensions of the much more modest territories they inherited from the Ming dynasty.

Chinese scholars also argue that while there may have been a distinctively Han character in the notion of China, this had begun to change with the experience of multi-ethnic existence under the long years of the Qing empire. The reformer Kang Youwei (1858–1927), an ethnic Han, argued